

18th-century British painting

While the Rococo was flourishing in France, different approaches to art emerged elsewhere. In Britain, inspired by new types of literature, or novels, that were often cautionary tales of vanity, dishonesty and duplicity, William Hogarth (1697–1764) created satirical paintings and prints. His visual stories were widely copied, and he lobbied in Parliament for greater legal control over the reproduction of artists' work. The result was the 1735 Engravers' Copyright Act (known as 'Hogarth's Act').

Joseph Wright of Derby (1734–97) trained as a portrait painter, but became renowned for his dramatically lit scenes. His use of strong chiaroscuro shows the influence of Caravaggio and Rembrandt. Following a close study of equine anatomy, George Stubbs (1724–1805) painted horses and scenes of peasant life. Thomas Gainsborough (1727–88) painted portraits and landscapes with a light palette and free brushstrokes, while Sir Joshua Reynolds (1723–92) painted dignified portraits using rich colours, strong lighting and a loose application of paint.



Hogarth, *Marriage à-la-Mode*, c.1743